

ABOUT-NARRATIVE-INTERVIEW-ANSWERS

This document is a companion to the narrative questionnaire. It preserves Alexander Beck's spoken answers in a form that retains nuance, examples and language before any editorial rewriting.

1. What gets lost when something is simplified badly?

Poor simplification removes nuance, flavour and emotion. In an AI-driven world, systems increasingly converge on the same patterns, creating 'copies of copies'. Corporate digital products often avoid personality in pursuit of universal appeal, but people connect with products that have character.

2. Describe one time you made something clearer without making it generic.

Apple and OpenAI demonstrate thoughtful reduction: removing unnecessary choice while taking responsibility for decisions on behalf of users. Clarity should reduce noise without removing emotion or identity.

3. What recurring tension in design interests you?

The tension between clarity and character. Digital products should be understandable and spatially memorable, while also feeling tactile and human. Physical objects like the Walkman inspire interfaces with a small number of meaningful controls rather than endless options.

4. What kind of simplification feels honest?

Honest simplification starts with users rather than trends. It removes friction without pretending complexity does not exist. It should never feel like corners were cut or minimalism was applied as a style.

5. When is complexity the kinder choice?

In complex domains such as financial products, complexity should be layered rather than removed. Navigation can be simple while advanced configuration remains available. This aligns with Tesler's Law: complexity can often be shifted but not eliminated.

6. What kind of simplicity do you distrust?

Simplicity that makes assumptions about behaviour, hides essential functionality or manipulates users. Products should express a clear purpose rather than stripping away capabilities indiscriminately.

7. What do people oversimplify?

The relationship between people and brands. AI-generated marketing often flattens personality into generic best practice, losing the premise and emotional connection behind a product.

8. How do you know you've simplified enough?

When further reduction would remove meaning or character rather than sharpen focus. Reduction should amplify the important things, not erase them.

9. Systems or stories?

Stories are harder to simplify because perspective matters. Systems have underlying structures; stories lose important nuance through excessive compression.

10. Tiny detail worth keeping.

A visible human footprint. Small imperfections or crafted details signal that another person made something for another person.

11. Working under pressure.

Pragmatism matters, but even under tight deadlines the work should retain a sense of character and integrity.

12. Recent examples.

American Heart Association: introduced tactility and softness into the interface while defining a system developers could implement. Personal website: relied on native CSS Scroll Snap and strong structural decisions rather than visual gimmicks.

13. Who do you simplify for?

Primarily users, but also stakeholders by helping them step back from organisational complexity. Simplification creates space for clearer thinking.

14. Living with unfinished simplification.

Discomfort becomes creative energy. Side projects such as redesigning the iOS keyboard explore questions that professional constraints cannot always answer.

15. Follow-up reflections.

Design becomes too thin when everything is only a system and nothing feels unique. Personality should be introduced selectively through crafted motion, interaction or visual moments inside a robust system. The aim is reliability, consistency and professionalism, balanced with delight and surprise.